CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

PHYSICIAN ASSISTANT IN THE AI ERA

AI can draft a differential. A physician assistant still takes the history, performs the exam, does the procedure and answers for the plan.

★ TL;DR — Median $135,880 with +21% growth and ~11,500 openings a year (BLS), on a 4+ year path: bachelor's, direct patient-care experience, a 2-year-plus accredited PA program, the PANCE exam and a state licence. The catch: the bottleneck is admission — programmes commonly expect 1,000–2,000 patient-care hours before you even apply. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

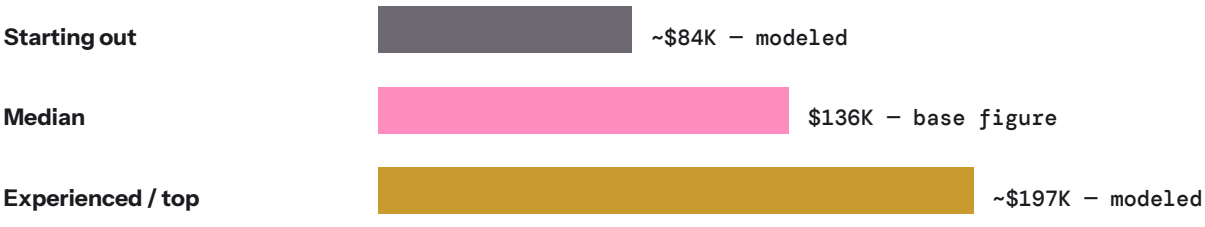
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$136K · TRAINING 4+ years · AI RISK LOW · STATE LICENSE

- +21% growth and ~11,500 openings a year on a $135,880 median. Older guides (and our old card) printed $120K — that understates the occupation by nearly $16K.
- AI lives in the chart, not the exam room: ambient scribes documented over 2.5 million encounters at Kaiser Permanente alone, and the scribe studies' burnout gains include PAs directly. The PA still examines, performs procedures and signs.
- Entry is institutionally built for beginners after licensure — postgraduate fellowships recruit new graduates directly. The fight is getting INTO school, not getting hired out of it.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Physician Assistant is a ~$136K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state,

employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A PHYSICIAN ASSISTANT ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Interview and examine patients, then develop diagnostic plans
- ✓ Order and interpret tests, diagnose illness and injury
- ✓ Perform procedures, assist in surgery or manage treatment depending on specialty
- ✓ Follow patients, adjust care and coordinate with the healthcare team

Think: a highly trained clinician built to move across specialties while working inside a medical team.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI can draft documentation, summarize histories, suggest studies and help review imaging or literature.	The exam, procedure, uncertainty, patient trust and responsibility for acting on incomplete information remain human work.

⚠ **Count the clock honestly: bachelor's (4 years, with science prerequisites) + commonly 1,000–2,000 direct patient-care hours + a 24–28-month full-time programme = six to seven years from zero. A strong GPA alone may not be enough, and PA school leaves little room for a normal job alongside it.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Medicine without committing your whole career to one specialty at the start ✓ A strong mix of thinking, procedures and patient contact ✓ Team-based work across clinics, hospitals, surgery and emergency care	✗ A demanding admissions race before the programme begins ✗ Full-time graduate study with heavy clinical rotations ✗ Responsibility and documentation pressure from the first job

Good fit? You love medicine and teamwork, learn science quickly and want broad clinical skills rather than one narrow lane.
Bad fit? You dislike hospitals, bodily fluids, urgent decisions or the idea of years of preparation before applying.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PREREQUISITES, EXPERIENCE, PA SCHOOL	DOOR B — CLINICAL JOB AS THE BRIDGE
Complete science prerequisites, earn direct patient-care experience and apply to an ARC-PA-accredited PA program. After graduation, pass the PANCE and obtain a state licence — required in all states and DC.	Work first as a medical assistant, EMT, scribe, phlebotomist or similar clinician-facing role. The bridge banks the patient-care hours admissions count while showing you the real pace of medicine.

Smart move: Choose patient-care experience where you touch patients and make observations, not a prestigious title with passive shadowing. Programs and employers can tell the difference. Where you land after: Experienced PA in a chosen specialty, then senior clinician, specialty lead, educator or clinical operations role.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
MAP THE	EARN REAL	APPLY LIKE	SURVIVE PA	CERTIFY AND	CHOOSE SPECIALTY

STEP 1 — Map the prerequisites

FREE · TODAY

- Compare target programs for science courses, grades, patient-care experience and deadlines.
- Budget the true timeline: bachelor's + care hours + 24–28 months of programme. The 4+ year clock starts now, not at orientation.

STEP 2 — Earn real patient-care experience

PAID · BEFORE YOU APPLY

- Work in a role with direct patient contact and clinical responsibility — programmes commonly expect 1,000–2,000 hours.
- Keep a record of settings, skills and patient populations you served.

STEP 3 — Apply like it is a campaign

COMPETITIVE · PLAN AHEAD

- Apply broadly to accredited programs that fit your record and geography.
- Use your statement to show clinical judgment and a realistic understanding of the PA role.

STEP 4 — Survive PA school

FULL TIME · 24–28 MONTHS

- Treat didactic study as system-by-system clinical reasoning, not memorization alone.
- Use rotations to test specialties and build a professional network.

STEP 5 — Certify and license

REQUIRED · AFTER GRADUATION

- Pass the Physician Assistant National Certifying Examination (PANCE).
- Complete state licensure and employer credentialing before starting practice.

STEP 6 — Choose specialty by fit

PAID · FIRST ROLE

- Look at new-grad fellowships — many recruit PAs straight out of programmes with a structured first year.
- Prioritize training, supervision and patient mix over a glamorous specialty label.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: make a prerequisite and patient-care gap list from several accredited programs.

□ Days 1–30: enroll in missing coursework or start a direct patient-care role.

□ Days 31–60: meet advisors or current PAs, refine your target list and track every requirement in one place.

□ Days 61–90: draft your application story and confirm letters, transcripts and deadlines are moving.

□ Day 90: you should be visibly closing the application gaps, not still deciding whether experience matters.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **MEDICINE IS A TEAM SPORT.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.